Before you begin

Asthma: my diary and my life story

Keeping a diary

Buy a notebook or journal that you keep just for this programme. Start writing in it today, every day until your cohort begins, and keep going through the 33 days. You don't need to change anything yet: just notice, and write it down. Nobody else needs to read it. Keep taking your medication as prescribed: this programme works alongside your doctor's advice, never instead of it.

Each time you have symptoms, or use your reliever inhaler, write down:

- The time, and where you are.
- What you noticed: wheezing, coughing, a tight chest, shortness of breath.
- What you were doing just before, and anything that might have set it off: exercise, cold air, dust, pollen, smoke, a cold, stress.
- How you felt just before, and during: calm, anxious, rushed, frightened.
- How strong the symptoms were, from 0 to 5.
- Which inhaler or medication you used, how many puffs, and how quickly it helped.

At the end of each day, write a few lines:

- Did I take my preventer medication as prescribed today?
- How many times did I need my reliever inhaler?
- Did I do my breathing practice today? How did my breathing feel afterwards?
- Did asthma wake me in the night, or stop me doing anything today?
- What emotions came up around my breathing today?
- One thing I noticed about myself today.

My life story

Take your time with these. Write in your journal over a few days, as much or as little as feels right. There are no right answers: just be honest with yourself.

1. When did you first have asthma symptoms? How old were you, and what was happening in your life at that time?

2. When were you diagnosed, and how did you feel about it then?

3. When did you first take medication for it? What were you given, and how did it feel to rely on it?

4. What medication do you use now: preventer, reliever, tablets? How much, and how often do you reach for your reliever?

5. How has your asthma changed over the years: times it was worse, better, or you hardly noticed it?

6. What sets it off for you: exercise, cold air, allergies, colds, smoke, stress, strong emotions?

7. Have you had a serious attack, or been to hospital? What do you remember, and how does it stay with you?

8. How do you breathe on an ordinary day: through your nose or mouth, high in the chest or low in the belly, fast or slow?

9. How does asthma affect your life: sleep, exercise, work, travel, confidence, how you feel about your body?

10. Who in your family has asthma or allergies? What did you learn about breathing and illness growing up?

11. What have you tried before to manage it, besides medication, and what did you learn from it?

12. What has brought you to this group, now?

13. Who are you becoming? Describe a day in your life breathing more easily.